present a 'united front'. Mrs. Sarojini Naidu pleads for it eloquently with all her poetic ardour. She is a poet and entitled to lay stress on the beauty of harmony and concord. Obviously a 'united front' is always desirable, provided it is a front. An analysis of this phrase leads one to the conclusion that what is aimed at is a pact or compromise between various individuals at the top. Such a combination will necessarily mean that the most cautious and moderate will determine the objective and lay down the pace. As some of them are well known to dislike all movement, the result will be a united standstill. Instead of a united front there will be a united and extensive display of back.

It is, of course, absurd to say that we will not co-operate with or compromise with others. Life and politics are much too complex for us always to think in straight lines. Even the implacable Lenin said that "to march forward without compromise, without turning from the path" was "intellectual childishness and not the serious tactics of a revolutionary class." Compromises there are bound to be, and we should not worry too much about them. But whether we compromise or refuse to do so, what matters is that primary things should come first always and secondary things should never take precedence over them. If we are clear about our principles and objectives, temporary compromises will not harm. But danger lies in our slurring over those principles and objectives for fear of offending our weaker brethren. To mislead is far worse than to offend.

I write vaguely and somewhat academically about current events, and try to play the part of a detached onlooker. I am not usually considered a looker-on when action beckons; my offence, I am often told, is that I rush in foolishly without sufficient provocation. What would I do now? What would I suggest to my countrymen to do? Perhaps the instinctive caution of a person who dabbles in public affairs comes in the way of my committing myself prematurely. But, if I may confess the truth, I really do not know and I do not try to find out. When I cannot act, why should I worry? I do worry to a large extent, but that is inevitable. At least, so long as I am in prison, I try to save myself from coming to grips with the problem of immediate action.

All activity seems to be far away in prison. One becomes the object of events, not the subject of action. And one waits and waits for something to happen. I write of political and social problems of India and the world, but what are they to this